



Sports key to getting the Irish up

The Irish have gone soft, which I can say from personal experience.

For many of us, our only exercise all year is marching in the St. Patrick's Day Parade every March 17, which happens to be this Monday. At that, it is not exactly a march. It is more like a leisurely stroll down Euclid Avenue. Many of us don't even walk; we ride, waving to our friends who stand motionless on the sidewalk.

Today the Irish spend a great deal of time reading their law books or studying their balance sheets.

I have heard the claim that people of Irish descent control more than half of this country's wealth.

This may be true. Just check the boards of directors of huge corporations or the country club rolls.

A couple of generations ago, Irish kids were the caddies, carrying doubles for a few hard-earned bucks.

Today many of these same kids are the members, riding around in golf carts.

In the early part of this century, the Irish dominated sports, particularly boxing and baseball. Most of the early heavyweight champions were Irish, from James Ambrose, born in 1813 in County Cork, Ireland, through James J. Braddock, who surrendered the title to Joe Louis in 1937.

Even Muhammad Ali claimed that he has Irish blood coursing through his veins, which accounts for his gift of poetry.

A distant cousin of my father's was Johnny Kilbane, a Cleveland native who held the featherweight title from 1912 to 1923, the longest uninterrupted reign in ring history.

Baseball's most famous family was not the DiMaggios or Alous. They were the Delahantys of Cleveland. Around the turn of the century five Delahanty brothers played major-league baseball and a sixth played in the minors. The greatest was hall of famer Ed Delahanty, whose .346 lifetime batting average is the fifth-highest in history.

Ed was playing for the Washington Senators in 1903 when his career ended at the age of 35. He was swept over Niagara Falls and his body was recovered several days later.

It seems that Ed had gotten into the bottle while traveling with the Senators for a road series and was causing a commotion on the train. The conductor ordered him off the train, whereupon it is theorized that Ed set out on foot across a trestle. In the darkness he slipped and fell into the Niagara River.

Many Irish take offense to the popular perception that the

See COUGHLIN, D9



TOM MAHL / CHRONICLE PHOTOS

TOUGH LOSS: Olmsted Falls players react in disbelief as their season comes to an end in Saturday's regional final.

Falls can't hold on

Benedictine bounces Bulldogs with fourth-quarter comeback

Jerry Rombach
The Chronicle-Telegram

TOLEDO — Something happened on the way to the state tournament for Olmsted Falls' boys basketball team Saturday.

The bus didn't exactly blow a tire, but the players went flat just as they were approaching the Columbus city limits.

Fourth-rated Olmsted Falls (23-2) blew a late 10-point lead to seventh-ranked Cleveland Benedictine (21-5) and lost 64-57 Saturday afternoon in the Division III regional championship game at Toledo's Savage Hall.

The Bengals, who also eliminated Falls' football team in the playoffs last November, outscored the Bulldogs by a whopping 27-12 margin in the fourth quarter.

And they did this without their second-best scorer and top rebounder, Tim Cheatwood, who was kicked off the team after an encounter with police

following a traffic violation last week. An all-state football player, Cheatwood is committed to attending Ohio State next fall.

"I knew we'd wear them down at the end," said Rashond Brown, Benedictine's sparkplug point guard who scored 25 points. "I saw (John) Storey in the game the other night and he played the whole game. I figured he'd wear out in the fourth."

Benedictine coach Frank Novak was also confident even when Falls had a 42-32 lead with 3:10 left in the third quarter.

"I called a timeout, so I knew we were in trouble," Novak said. "But I just didn't want it to get out of control. I was sure we could come back. We've been down by that many several times this year, and to some pretty tough opponents. We play a very strong schedule and I think that showed today."

See FALLS, D7



STOREY TIME: Olmsted Falls senior guard John Storey, right, looks for an opening against Benedictine's Rashon Brown.

One up on Rupp

Tar Heel win gives Smith all-time record 877th victory

Chris Dufresne
Los Angeles Times

WINSTON-SALEM, N.C. — Serge Zwikker went after the ball like a 7-foot-3 center possessed. It was his best move of the day, by far, picking the ball clean from Colorado's Rick Brownstein at midcourt amid the chaos.

The game?

The game was over. This was about posterity.

A female arena worker then tried to con the ball from Zwikker, who didn't just fall off a turnip steamer from Maassluis, Netherlands.

"She wanted that ball pretty bad," Zwikker later recounted.

"She said, 'We're going to give it to him later.' I said, 'That's all right, we're going to give it to him right now.'"

Zwikker took his gift directly to the new king.

"Coach, here's the ball," Zwikker said.

Dean Smith accepted the orb.

"This ball represents a lot of history," he would reply.

And it was over. The record Smith said he never wanted to break was broken.

As several of his former players watched from the stands, Smith's current North Carolina incarnation made sure the overtaking of Adolph Rupp's record of 876 victories would be done Saturday, on a national stage, in North Carolina.

After playing a nervous first half, the Tar Heels came scream-



Smith

See SMITH, D9

Tribe joy might not last

WINTER HAVEN, Fla. — Welcome to Camp Cheerful.

Just about everyone here at the Indians' spring training camp is happy. Maybe it's the weather. Maybe it's the new blood on the team. Or maybe it's because what's-his-name isn't around.

Even though John Hart didn't reel in any of the big free agents he wanted, the general manager knows he has put together another solid team that could get back to the World Series.

Even though he has little job security, Mike Hargrove is as relaxed as he's been since taking the job in 1991. Hargrove has confidence in his players. He has confidence in his ability to take the team a long way. And he has confidence in his ability that if things don't work out here, another team will look at his



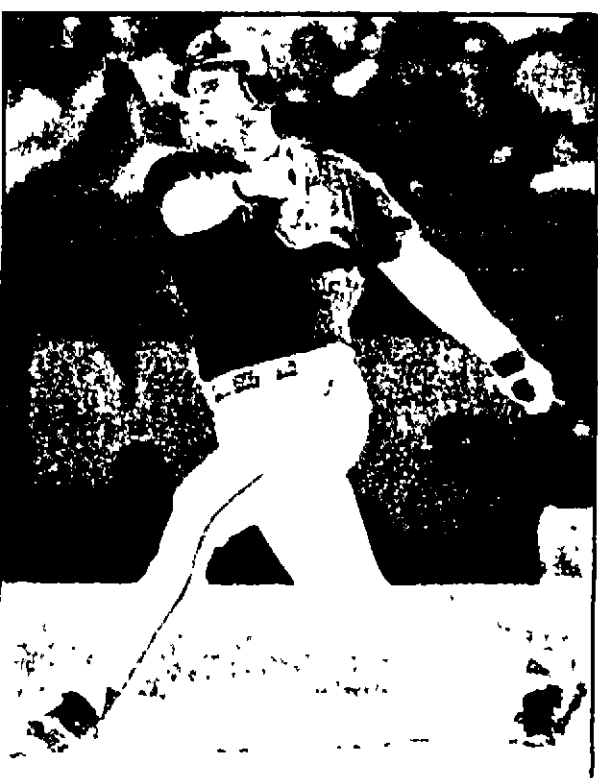
record and give him a job.

A visitor walks into the clubhouse and actually sees smiling faces.

This is a team that should be favored to win its third straight division title. It's one of the top two or three teams in the American League again.

However, there are two clouds hanging over the Indians. One is Omar Vizquel's sore shoulder.

See HERRICK, D3



KIMBERLY BARTH / CHRONICLE

WELCOME, MATT: Indians third baseman Matt Williams takes a cut during Saturday's 5-3 loss to Kansas City. Williams was making his first appearance after missing four games with an injury. Details in Tribe Notes on D3.

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